

Zamenis situla

Leopard snake

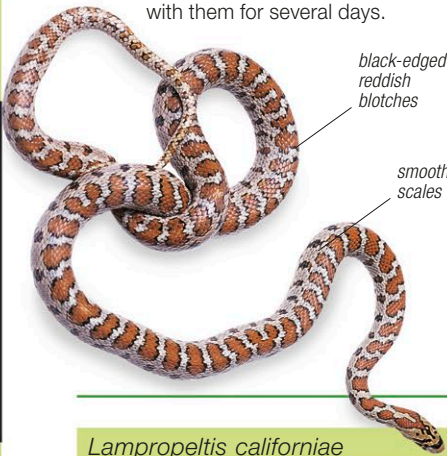


Length 28–39 in (70–100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S. and E. Europe, W. Asia



The leopard snake is cream or gray, with black-edged reddish blotches, or 2 wide, longitudinal reddish stripes, edged with black, along its upper side. It feeds mainly on rodents, which it catches among vegetation or in their burrows, then kills by constriction. If threatened, it may flatten its head and bite. During mating, the male holds onto the female by biting her head or neck and coiling around her. Females lay up to 8 eggs and remain with them for several days.



Erpeton tentaculatum

Tentacled snake



Length 28–39 in (70–100 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Least concern

Location Central S.E. Asia



This unusual snake belongs to a subfamily of colubrids—numbering about 38 species in all—that live in water. It is easily distinguished from its relatives by the unique pair of soft, fleshy tentacles on its snout, which probably have a sensory function. Tentacled snakes are sluggish and nocturnal, and hunt by lying in weed-choked water, waiting for prey to swim by. Females give birth to 5–13 live young underwater.

Gonyosoma oxycephalum

Red-tailed racer

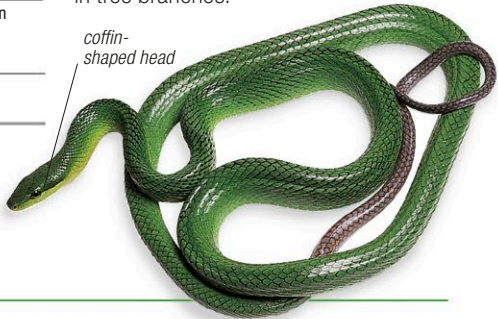


Length 5¼–7¾ ft (1.6–2.4 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Asia



The tail of this long, slender snake may be brown, orange, or gray, but despite its name it is never red. An active hunter, the red-tailed racer forages for



birds, bats, and small mammals at night, its bright green color providing excellent camouflage in the trees. When threatened, usually by birds of prey or mammals, it inflates its throat vertically and adopts an S-shaped posture, in readiness to strike. Mating occurs in tree branches.

Heterodon nasicus

Western hognosed snake



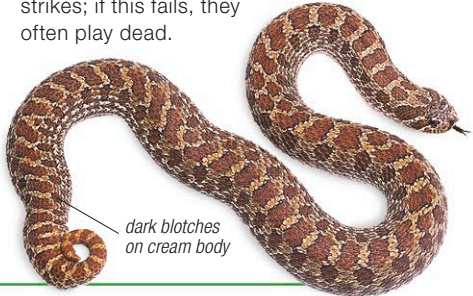
Length 16–32 in (40–80 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location C. USA to Mexico



With its blotched patterning and thick body, this North American snake looks more like a viper (see p.402) than a member of the colubrid family. Although its venom is toxic, it is

not considered dangerous to humans. There are 3 species of hognosed snakes in North America, all of which search through the soil or sand for their prey and use their distinctive, upturned snouts for digging and rooting out burrowing toads and other amphibians. If threatened, all hognosed snakes hiss loudly, inflate their bodies, and may make mock strikes; if this fails, they often play dead.



Lampropeltis californiae

Californian kingsnake



Length 3¼–6½ ft (1–2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.W. USA and N.W. Mexico

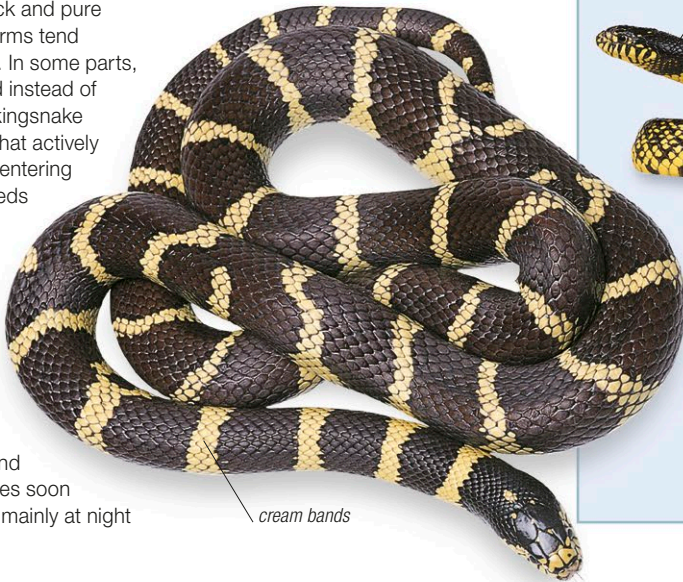


The Californian kingsnake is a boldly marked species. Populations from desert regions are jet black and pure white, whereas coastal forms tend toward brown and cream. In some parts, the snakes can be striped instead of banded. The Californian kingsnake is a powerful constrictor that actively hunts for prey, frequently entering rodent burrows. It also feeds on birds, lizards, frogs, and other snakes, including rattlesnakes, to whose bite it is immune. Although mainly terrestrial, this snake may climb into low vegetation in search of nestling birds. If threatened it may strike and bite vigorously, but captives soon become tame. It is active mainly at night

and in the evening, and hibernates during the coldest months. Mating takes place in spring, with the male crawling along the female's back and biting her neck to hold her still. The female lays 5–12 eggs—although it is known to have laid up to 25 eggs—in underground chambers, rotting stumps, or leaf litter. The young hatch after about 70 days and measure about 12–14 in (30–35 cm) in length.

VARIED PATTERNS

The Californian kingsnake is usually black or dark brown with white or cream bands, although some populations include striped individuals (see panel, right).



A BEWILDERING DIVERSITY

Kingsnakes occur in a wide variety of colors and patterns. They were all previously considered to be part of the same species, but are now divided into five separate species. To complicate matters further, the markings of some of them, such as the Californian kingsnake, are highly variable.

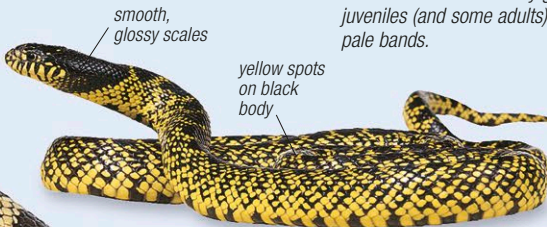


BLACK AS NIGHT

Mexican black kingsnake is simply a very dark form of the Californian kingsnake in which the markings become obscured as they grow. Hatchlings and juveniles (and some adults) often show traces of pale bands.

LAMPROPELTIS SPLENDIDA

This desert species from Arizona is only active for a short period of the year, when it is neither too cold nor too hot.



LAMPROPELTIS CALIFORNIÆ

The striped form of the Californian kingsnake occurs in some parts of the subspecies' range alongside the banded form (left). Both forms can hatch from the same clutch of eggs.

